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Section Title(S): Gestures And Salutations

Gestures and salutations

There is a Dholuo saying: 'Ka Lang'o ok kun e kuon.' 'One cannot be coy, or choosy, about a Lang'o goodwill gesture.'

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This saying, or proverb, refers to the manners of association with others. If the 'Lang'o', the others, offer you meat you do not hesitate in accepting. If you hesitate, the 'Lang'o' will eat it.

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It is understood that the 'Lang'o' does not invite you to 'possess'; rather, he invites you to 'share'. The realms of manners between 'us' and 'them' are exposed as different. The proverb reminds the 'us' that in this setting of tension, in the interaction with the other, one should accept the rhythm, the etiquette, the presentation of the other group. An implication is that to abstain is to lose all opportunity. The still deeper meaning is that 'I', as one of 'us', improve my position, or in difficult times survive, by acknowledging,

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accepting, the terms of the 'other'. One's identity as 'us' is articulated, reinforced, by accepting the terms, manners, routines, of the 'other'.

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There is marvellous and powerful paradox in the meanings and intentionalities of this proverb. It has its hidden history. The proverb exclaimed and instructed about the boundary between 'us' and the 'Lang'o' even as, one hundred to three hundred years ago, the Omolo, and other groups possibly referred to as Lang'o at one time or place, were brought within the fold of Dholuo-speaking communities. In another way, the proverb reiterates the power of everyday life in the constitution of ethnic boundaries and identities.

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[A] ... factor which restricts the [Luo] children's mobility is the practice of Luo mothers or mother-surrogates of telling children that they will be taken by a lion or a *jalango* if they stray far from the homestead. The term *jalango*, in this particular area, was a reference term for Masai, who had a common territorial boundary with the Luo. The children are cautioned also to be wary of strangers who visit the homestead when the parents are away, again for the same reason, i.e. that the children may be stolen.¹

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Today, the Siaya man or woman participates and derives his and her identity from a network of affective relations with brother, uncle, grandfather, in-law, friend, if not also from that little homunculus that resides on her own or his own shoulder. The individual's identity is crucial in terms of the structuring of communication, civility, and co-operation. The salutation or greeting of one person by another provides the context for initial conversation. An assembly of elders playing Ajua at Boro will greet a returning member of the urban salariat through all his simultaneous identities. The structure, in regard to a man coming upon this assembly, may run as follows: 27

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How are you?

The son of Gangu? [referring to an ancient settlement — *gunda bur*];

The son of Boro? [the identification of a present locational reference];

The son of Agutu? [bringing notice of a respected mother];

The son of Karuoth? [referencing a clan identity];

The son of the rulers? [referring to the claims to ancient domination and present legitimacy of the lineage or clan of the traveller];

The nephew to the Usonga people? [referencing a prestigious pedigree];

The cousin of Okoth the Night Runner? [referring to the relevance of a shared story of bravado];

The son of the people who roasted crocodile? [a humouring and at the same time respectful glance at a brave reputation];

The son of the brewers of the sausage tree? [a joking reference to stories of revelry];

Our son? [a summary and empowering implication that the traveller is one of us].

1. Benny Garell Blount, 'Acquisition of language by Luo children', PhD dissertation, University of California, Berkeley, 1969, p. 27. The historical borderland of Dholuo speech in western Kenya defies detailed mapping due to extensive intermarriage and clientelage among individuals born to different natal speech communities. The historical borderland is also marked by considerable bilingualism. That there were marriage, client, and exchange relations among groups of predominantly different speech does not lessen — in fact may enlarge — the scope for fierce stereotyping of others. For a fine discussion of this point see, Margaret Jean Hay, 'Local trade and ethnicity in western Kenya', *African Economic History Review*, 2, 1 (1975), pp. 7–12.

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